Personal Statement

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When I was eight, my parents moved our family from the Middle East to Australia to give my brother and me a better future. When my dad struggled to find work, they made the tough decision to live apart: my mum raised us in Australia, effectively as a single parent for almost two decades, while my dad worked long hours overseas to send money home and visit a few times a year.

As I look back on my high school and university experiences, I think a lot about how important my family and the informal safety net they provided was to my journey to graduate school. I could take risks in my career, take on more study or choose more demanding jobs because I had informal support. But I also think a lot about how getting through the door to these opportunities required government support; I went to a public university, used government-issued university loans, and relied income assistance when studying full-time. Both government assistance and family support played complementary roles in helping my career.

But I've also seen examples where both fall short. I watched as my brother was unemployed for over three years and needed more than just the imperfect income assistance provided by unemployment insurance. Like most young Australians, he is college educated, but job-search in fields like IT and computer science is incredibily challenging because the nature of these jobs are rapidly changing to due AI. Government programs aren't well-positioned to alleviate labour-market scarring in the face of such technological disruption.At the same time, moral support from family can often be viewed as patronising or insensitive, and financial support to wedge the gap that unemployment insurance creates can only last so long.

Word count: 240 (limit: 125–250)